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“Not Your Footballs!” Newly Formed Union of Non-Permanent Maruti-Suzuki Employees Intensifies Agitation, Calls Out Abuse of Contract Workers

Thousands of current and former non-permanent Maruti-Suzuki workers gathered at the Gurgaon DC office on 10th January 2025 to submit their charter of demands — challenging the company's hire-and-fire labour practices and demanding equal pay and permanent employment alongside the already-protesting terminated workers.

BY MOULI SHARMA

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*Following is the official press release of the Maruti Suzuki Asthayi Workers Sangh for their demonstration outside the DC office in Rajiv Chowk, Gurgaon on the **10th of January 2025**, where thousands of workers from several states joined those in Haryana, which has been the epicentre of the Maruti Movement since 2011. The agitation of Non-Permanent workers^[1] started on 5th January, and stands hand in hand with the already protesting^[2] terminated workers union, the Maruti Workers Struggle Committee, which has been on an indefinite strike near the company's Manesar plant since September 18th 2024.*

January 10, Gurgaon: Thousands of current and erstwhile non-permanent workers of Maruti Suzuki gathered at the Gurgaon DC office to submit their collective charter of demands to the Labour Department challenging the illegal labour practices of the company. The workers have organised themselves under the Maruti Suzuki Asthayi Mazdoor Sangh, launched on the 5th of January, 2025 in a mass meeting held at Krishna Chowk, Gurgaon. The charter of demands was also submitted to the company management on January 9, 2025.

The labour department has scheduled a tripartite meeting with the company management and the Sangh on January 31, 2025. The demonstration also submitted a memorandum to the Chief Minister of Haryana and declared a massive mobilization and workers march in IMT Manesar on the 30th of January. A working committee of non-permanent workers from different states and representatives from among the Maruti terminated workers is leading the agitation.

The workers have demanded an end to the reliance on various categories of temporary workers for regular production in all plants of the automobile giant. They are demanding permanent employment for work of a permanent nature, equal pay for equal work, hiring of temporary workers previously and presently employed by the company to all the plants as permanent workers including the new plant in Kharkhoda, Sonipat and ensuring useful and recognized training of Maruti Student trainees and apprentices. Non-permanent workers arriving into the area for the agitation have been camping at the protest site of terminated Maruti Workers at the Manesar Tehsil near IMT Manesar Chowk, seven kilometers from the company gate.

“Workers are not footballs to be kicked out at your whim!” Sumit, a temporary worker from Bahadurgarh gave the movement its defining metaphor of temporary workers being footballs kicked around from company to company. The image comes from his own 12 year long experience in the automobile industry where he has worked in the Hero car plant in Noida and the Hero bike plant in Manesar besides various stints in Maruti Suzuki.

Suzuki employs more than 34,918 workers out of which only 18% are permanent, 40.72% are contractual workers, 21.6% are temporary workers (TW), 21% are student trainees (MST) and apprentices. Workers are trapped in an infinite cycle of hope and despair as the company hires them for short spans extending to seven months to one-two years and then releases them promising to call them again after a few months. Trainee Workers are first hired as TW1, of which around 10% are rehired after a year as TW2 and a handful are called as TW3. The same logic operates for Contract workers who are called CW1, CW2 and CW3. This creates an extended relationship between the company and a massive pool of skilled labour kept in suspended and partial unemployment for years with short stints in employment at the convenience of the company.

The massive pay gap between permanent workers receiving an average monthly salary of 1,30,000 and non-permanent employees who receive 18,000 to 30,000 is another major bone of contention for the workers. Despite the main workload depending on this non-permanent workforce, there exists a great disparity in the facilities enjoyed by permanent and temporary workforces. A large part of the salary consists of incentives which are easily deducted for temporary workers on taking leaves, or fluctuations of production targets.

Twelve years after the Manesar agitation, workers face the same issues. Maruti Suzuki management became infamous after workers of its Manesar plant spent a whole year in agitation for the formation of their union in 2011-12. The agitation was sought to be crushed by a massive breakout of violence on July 18, 2012 leading to the death of a management executive from asphyxiation in the fire. The incident was followed by widespread police repression and the arrest of 117 workers of which the entire original union body was sentenced to life imprisonment. 23,000 permanent and contractual workers were terminated without an inquiry after the incident. At the root of the agitation was the grievance of unbearable work pressure, insufficient wages and widespread use of contractual workers in production. Permanent workers terminated in 2012 have been sitting in an indefinite sit-in in IMT Manesar since October, 2024 and have been instrumental in the build up of the present agitation claiming that the present movement is a continuation of the demands which had prompted them to begin agitating for a union in the first place.

The management had claimed that it had done away with contract workers after the agitation, and addressed the grievances of the workers. The present agitation reveals how these claims stand valid only for the small permanent workforce in the plant, whereas the majority of the workforce continues to be plagued by bad working conditions such as inability to take bathroom breaks, being marked as absent for a delay of mere seconds in signing into the plant, deduction of a sizeable portion of their salary for not achieving full attendance, only 7 mins for tea and half an hour for lunch within which workers have to walk for over a kilometer to go to the mess and come back.

The sham of skill development

Every year thousands of youth are churned out of various Maruti Suzuki plants as Student Trainees and apprentices. They are admitted under the Maruti Suzuki ITI program but are engaged in direct production, being made to work at the same station, turning the same nut and bolt for a year or two years depending on their trade and then released with a certificate which holds no meaning in the labour market. Sandeep (age 25) is fighting a case in the Haryana High Court because he was refused recruitment in a Haryana government job where his experience certificate from Maruti was refused recognition because it mentioned no specific work experience.

The company is a happy contributor to the government's claim to generating thousands of new jobs every year. But the massive gathering of workers reveals the dark reality behind these claims, where all this employment is merely ephemeral, lasting not more than a few months. The claims of upskilling through the National Employment Enhancement Mission are in fact just a façade to provide cheap skilled labour to companies like Maruti Suzuki.

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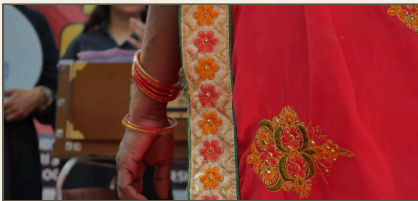
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Mouli Sharma is a journalist, freelance illustrator, and writer from New Delhi, India. She is a published photojournalist & illustrator, having been featured in The Hindu College Gazette, & the quarterly Pink Disco. Mouli took over as the Editor of The Voice Express (<https://thevoiceexpress.github.io/e-mag/>) back in September 2023.

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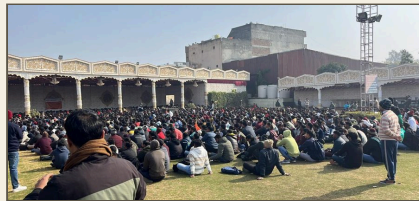
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[1] Non-Permanent workers

[2] already protesting